

To Val

LEARNING TO LABOR

HOW WORKING CLASS KIDS
GET WORKING CLASS JOBS

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7 The role of ideology

So far we have traced certain cultural penetrations and shown how they pass through internal 'limitations' into a surprising affirmation of manual labour power.

This has, of course, been at the risk of underemphasising the impact of external forces, state institutions and dominant ideologies acting upon working class kids. Though it is impossible in one study to delineate the full complexity of the cultural level with respect to outside determinants and structures it is possible to suggest one important form of interface between culture and ideology. Basically this is that ideology works on and in, produces and is partly produced by, the cultural. Ideology is, itself, partly influenced by cultural production, and for that, contains a modality and effectivity within cultural processes.

We have seen in the section on ethnography that many forms of the conventional dominant ideology – particularly as mediated through the school – are minced up, inverted or simply defeated by the counter-school culture. The crucial divisions, distortions and transferences which have been examined arise very often not so much from ideas and values mediated *downward* from the dominant social group, but from internal cultural relationships. Certain aspects of the working class cultural affirmation of manual labour considered here are profoundly important both ideologically and materially, and are, if anything, exported upwards to a largely uncomprehending official ideological apparatus. Division, sexism, racism and expression through manual labour power all occur much more strongly in civil society than in any state institution. In fact liberal democracy seems to set its face against these things. Its agents regard them as evils to be eradicated, not as the conditions of their own existence. This, of course, does not prevent the upwards export of ideological factors being used by the state, nor does it prevent the state from helping to reproduce them in contradictory and unintended ways. Indeed the good faith of state agents in various institutions may be one of the most important conditions for this reproduction under the regime of 'freedom' and 'equality' of the capitalist order.

We cannot, however, reverse the classic flow of ideology completely and suggest that the dominant ideology, state agencies and institutions take no active part in cultural processes other than providing the contexts in which they work.

It is these more direct, or 'dominant', effects which I reserve to the received notion of 'ideology'. They play an important role in the further limitation of cultural penetrations. They arise partly from the 'ruling ideas' of the age embodied in concrete institutions, and also in more informal media (TV, radio, press, film). They can be integrated on common ground – in the school for instance. Both, but especially the second, are influenced by and utilise meanings (differentially with differential distortions) and categories fed up to them from located class cultural processes.

For our purposes the two most important 'downward' vertical impacts of ideology on the counter-school culture are those of confirmation and dislocation. They confirm (in a somewhat circular fashion) those aspects and resolutions of cultural processes which are most partial to the current social organisation of interests and production, and dislocate (bringing something new into the local system) those which retain a degree of critical penetration of that system. Though they do not directly intervene in the subjective and cultural preparation of labour power, they play over, work up, and accentuate the real experiential processes. There is no machiavellian will in this, and elements of the proffered ideology are taken up only in precise articulation with real movement of working class cultural processes which, as we have seen, are rarely properly understood from above. Though the sense and logic of ideology may lie outside the cultural process, especially as contrasted with their internal generation of meaning, they are only taken up at different times and in different ways with respect to the contours and logics of particular cultural forms.

Confirmation

Careers teaching and advice is the most explicit ideological force bearing down on 'the lads' during their preparation for work. We saw before that the denoted aspects of careers advice and work are heavily blocked and re-interpreted. Some what we may term connoted messages do get through however, especially in terms of reinforcing the naturalism of social divisions, sexism and the inevitability of certain kinds of work already forming in the culture. Often it is not intended to transmit this information. It concerns such things as the general ambience of working life; a fascination with processes and machines; the division between those who work with their hands, and those who work with their heads; the apparent timelessness and inevitability of industrial organisation; the atomised competitive nature of the world of work around the corner; the hardness and inevitability of industrial work. It is not meant to be part, and is not received as part, of the general model which is presented for a rational careers choice. It comes from the sheer exposure to a vast number of films where working class people are seen working; from the apparently bewildering variety of jobs available; from film of moving machinery shot with a cameraman's instinct for the compulsive; from the utter assumption of authority in white collars directing blue coats.

Perhaps the clearest example here is that of role differentiation between the sexes in careers films. There is no obvious discrimination, and sex role stereotyping is never the subject of comment in these films. If anything, the explicit emphasis is developing more towards equality between the sexes, but the visual images and implied assumptions remain sexually divisive and are picked up by the sexism of 'the lads'.

In a cake factory we see only girls working and the voice-over tells us as we watch a girl icing a cake, 'Yes, she really is doing it that quickly, the film isn't

speeded up'. Women are always doing intricate and fiddly things. Their only relation to more heroic occupations is one of fear and concern for their menfolk. In a film on trawling the young seaman is shown leaving an anxious and uncertain mother waving on the doorstep of her own proper domain, the home. She disappears back into the house when he is out of sight apparently to wait and brood there until his return. In contrast to this obvious display of feeling the male captain on the trawler is portrayed as a remote and powerful figure 'who cannot afford to show emotion'. His attention is on the size of the catch - not on the pastoral care of his new crewman.

In another film on farming the hardness and toughness of the life is not concealed, but neither is a dignity and stature which can only be referenced against masculine themes. The voice-over tells us that 'driving a tractor is not as easy as it looks', though Tom in the film finds it easy because 'he drove earthmoving equipment in the war'. In a concluding summary what can only be assumed to be a masculine audience is told that 'it's a hard life, but not for someone who's set their heart on it'.

One of the most important general functions of ideology is the way in which it turns uncertain and fragile cultural resolutions and outcomes into a pervasive naturalism. Ideology supplies many more examples to fix the one. The least challenging and most mystified cultural productions from below are shaped, concretised and supported to form a real and lived common denominator which allows all classes to come together into a kind of consensus which is the basis for reproduction of the status quo and the stage-army show of democracy. It is a consensus which may actually work against aspects of the official ideological canons. Still this is a small price to pay for stability, and is the form of a messy ideological concession which matches the more tangible concessions made to labour and social democratic demands from below. For the working class it often marks the break from one absolutism, bourgeois ideology, to a profounder one: the law of nature, the rule of commonsense.

For 'the lads' this hegemony of commonsense surrounds them all the time. It is partly self-created and partly produced by confirmatory ideological messages downwards. It is the apparent basis of action for those around them. It supplies naturalised social divisions and an omnipresent sexual chauvinism. Perhaps most important, and in a confirming distortion of their already distorted sense of their own labour power, it supplies an overpowering feeling that the way of the world is the way of work. Work of a certain direct and concrete kind. Even in their defiant and deviant acts there is always the reminder of this way. As they run from a shop with a stolen cake the shopkeeper shouts after them, 'I've got to work for that four bob'; when they have broken a chair in the school they are told, 'Your father worked for that'; at home they are told and shown in a multitude of ways, 'if you won't work you won't eat'.

Whilst work on the world must be done there are many ways of organising it. Their buried cultural penetrations tell 'the lads' more about its real social organisation than does this assertion of the blank necessity of work. It is a reification of the

most partial and limited of their cultural 'insights'. It prevents their development into an exploration of other more equal and rational organisations of production.[1]

The subversion of ordered and sequential time implicit in the rhythm of the counter-school culture, whilst potentially radical in its implications, and whilst avoiding the tyranny of the 'narrative which follows', is delivered into inertia and domination by being profoundly naturalised. Time may not be that of constructed industrialism, but nor is it that of revolutionary choice. Bourgeois time is contrasted (in the lived out cultural forms) not with relativism and possibility, but with changeless nature and its inert drift. The break from bourgeois time is to a more absolute time. The 'partial penetration' of bourgeois time, as with so many other 'insights', becomes the reduction back of the cultural and relatively arbitrary to the 'natural', not its projection forward into new forms. It is the denial of history not the claiming of history, despite the promise of its break.

Dislocation

One of the main dislocating tendencies of ideology as it is expressed through the school and careers work is characteristically unintended.

As we have seen, the dominant form of careers teaching and 'teaching for life' stresses the real differentiation of job opportunities and their capacity to satisfy the range of human aspirations and hopes in a horizontal as well as a vertical direction. This direct thrust is largely deflected and its false logic penetrated by the counter-school culture. So far as 'the lads' are concerned, all jobs are basically the same. The ideological thrust is a very strong one, however, and it helps to dislocate cultural penetrations.

Since the ideological force for differentiation is so strong, and since it cannot convince its proper object, the effect of its thrust is reversed and acts centripetally, not to make jobs various, but to decentre the cause of their sameness. The lack of variety in work does not seem to have a simple cause (the productive logic of capitalism). The bewildering variety of films, the succession of speakers and the continuous pressure from staff to make a 'choice' from 'choices' acts, not to show variety of work in the world, but rather the amazing sameness of work across such a varied area and from such a variety of determinants and causes.

It is thus no one's fault that work is boring and tiring and mostly meaningless. There is no one to blame, no action to be taken, no fellow sufferers from the *same* rod. It seems natural that very different areas such as farming, milk rounds and factory work all turn out to have bosses breathing down the worker's neck, and boring work to be done in order to obtain the magic brown envelope. This feeds into, and is strengthened by, the naturalism considered earlier. Instead of a centred world of oppression from a specific and determinate social organisation of thought, production and interests we have the naturalistic world of a thousand timeless causes. Multi-determination brings misery and is the human condition. A single

enemy might be fought, but never a million little ones pricking out the contours of the human condition.

A more direct dislocation of the informal group which aids the decentring and suppression of cultural penetrations is achieved in careers work sometimes, by an explicit stress on individualism. In the Hammertown school it is common practice to use the threat of the future and the competitiveness of the world of work to drive a wedge into the solidarity of the group:

Careers teacher to fifth year I've told you before, it's not often I advocate selfishness but in this case I must. Forget your friends sitting around you now, you might be together now, having a laugh, and it doesn't matter. But all the friends in the world are no use when it comes to finding a job. When it comes to that you're on your own, you've got to do it by yourself and no one can help (...) So, just this time, be selfish, don't worry what your friends are doing, you get out and look after number one, sort out your own jobs and don't wait for your mates.

Of course, given the situation this is good advice, especially on an individual level – and it is made honestly and with care. The run-up to the end of the last year with half the fifth without a job is a thoroughly frightening prospect for all concerned: pragmatic individual decisions do need to be made. The pressure for jobs is much worse now than it was. The fact still remains, however, that ideology has always claimed necessity for its own, and used shortness of time to forestall other perspectives and possibilities.

This force for the disintegration of the group and its perspective or more exactly for the prevention of its proper emergence, can be aided by the interview with the careers officer. Often without much direct influence on 'the lads', its individualistic and sometimes meritocratic logic can sow the seeds of dissent which can flower – despite the countervailing cultural forces – into muffled forms of individualism and demarcation.

Certainly towards the end of the last year when employment looms ahead the individualistic differentiation suggested by the dominant ideology shows some firm roots through its cultural antinomy:

[In a group discussion]

Fuzz I went in [to the careers interview], what it was ... she tried to push anything onto me, 'You wanna be a paver', her says (...) 'Do you wanna be a typewriter mender', I ain't said nothing about typewriters [laughter]. She says, 'Well, I'll just try and find some places for you, and I'll let you know'.

Joey She knows what you can do, she ain't gettin', how much, thirty quid a week, for nothing. She's gotta know what the strength is, she probably knows what you're capable of (...)

Fuzz She does like, she tries to push you off the job.

Fred You want, say your mind's set, she'll push it off. Yeah, I had mechanics on my mind and she put me off it (...) she says you ain't gonna get this because you need physics and all this lot.

Joey Well, that's it, that's what she knows, she knows you wouldn't get it.

Spike 'Cos if you applied for a job like that, and you know what you've gotta have, her tells you you've got to have physics, well ... it's just wasting time, unless you're willing to learn (...)

Will She's putting yer on the right lines, save wasting say a year while yer training and then they chuck yer out. Know what I mean, if you ain't capable of it like.

These are the main dislocating effects of the careers dynamic on the penetrations formed at the cultural level. This ideological play across cultural radicalism in conjunction with internal weaknesses pervaded and confirmed with naturalism cumulatively helps to produce an immobility characteristic, generally, of the working class. Although inequalities are often seen, exploitation recognised, and injustices and contradictions experienced every day, none of these things seems to point in the same direction. They do not have a common cause. If some exploit and some are exploited, if some are equal and others unequal this does not happen with the systematisation of classes. All have the chance to exploit others as well as be exploited. Nor can any system ever hope to change this. Chance, fate and luck basically deal the cards in any game. A quite marked degree of disenchantment with the prevailing system and a degree of knowledge of exploitation, coupled with culturally mediated (though distorted) and partially lived out penetrations of the capitalist system, can co-exist with a calm acceptance of the system and belief that there is no systematic suppression of personal chances in life. Suppression is recognised, but as no more than a random part of the human condition. Human nature, not capitalism, is the trap. Ideology has helped to produce that – though not simply from its own resources: it is believed, because it is partly self-made.

[In an individual interview at work]

John (working in a small factory producing a range of car accessories) There's always more stuff waiting [to work on] but I mean, even me, I mean I'm on twelve pound a week. In a day I could bring a thousand pound in for 'em. I mean everything you're doing is money.

PW What do you make of that?

John I think every place, the management are better off ... everywhere you'll find the same (...)

PW Yet you still say things, by and large, are fair.

John It's fair on the whole, but I mean obviously there is points where it ain't fair, like management, but I think it's everybody's fault, everybody's too greedy, that's all it is. I mean, even the poorest

of people, if they won, say, a million quid, they'd start . . . they'd still want more money although they'd be in a situation where they know people can't eat and things, they won't start giving it away to poorer people. Just everybody in general, they got greedy. But I think it's as fair as it can be.

[In an individual interview at work]

PW I mean do you ever feel that (. . .) you're earning that, (. . .) the director's salary or profit?

Bill (trainee machinist in a wood machine shop) Well it happens to everybody, it's got to, I think so anyway. But there's nothing you can do about it, it happens to everybody who works in a factory, not just this factory (. . .) I'd hope I can get up there, without them thinking about me, you know . . .

The internal interlocutor

The main importance of 'ideology' for the position outlined in this book lies not perhaps so much in its direct intervention (here only partially explored) or in its institutional supports or its political context, though these are important, so much as in the whole mode of its interface with the cultural process. In our contemporary working class culture ideology can be considered as the complement of informality.

The fundamental weakness in cultural forms is the *mediated* nature of personal experience and validation as they overlay and are influenced by cultural penetrations. Though the latter are the ultimate basis of relevance and vitality in a culture they are never expressed explicitly. They are not direct resources for struggle, they only have a similarity *in the stage of our analysis* with direct political statement: they do not replace policies or the level of conscious analysis. The very concreteness, denseness, buried radicalism, and relevance of informal cultural processes, and the very substance of their claim on individuals is their greatest weakness in the larger social context. The nature of informality as a mode of opposition in this society is that it reserves itself as the exception to the rule. It is blind to all of the other exceptions which together could overthrow the rule. It is unaware of its own 'rules'. The analysis of the world which actually directs its distinctively cultural responses remains silent. It is into this silence that ideology confidently strides. Whether right or wrong, whether penetrated or not it is *the* rule, it is *the* voice. It becomes the internal interlocutor for the weakness of cultural forms. Powerful ideologies, no matter what their content, always have the gift of formality, publicness and explicit statement. They can work within the scope of consensus and consent because nothing in oppositional *cultural* processes can displace their level of action and effectiveness.

In the case of 'the lads' and the counter-school culture there is a surprising tension and contradiction between those non-conformist and oppositional views which reject the institution and conventional morality. This contradiction is not

always apparent. Its subterranean presence, however, reinforces the brake on cultural penetrations, limited as they are, and helps to further disorganise them and project their meanings on to unlikely objects.

Certainly every 'lad' occupies the contradiction in his own way, with different pressures of feeling and different kinds of resolution. It is the cultural *itself* which exhibits the surprising and continuing ambiguity. The logic of non-conformism, rejection and instrumentalism certainly underlies many actions, choices and behaviour. But this logic is always susceptible to being seen as an exception to the larger morality: the logic that holds for everyone else. The strength of personal experience - knowing how things really are - may over-ride this general logic for the purposes of daily life, but it by no means defeats it. Though the culture says to the individual, 'This is right for me', it can also seem to add 'even though it may be wrong in general'. The informal guides and validates real behaviour but it is held ultimately in the larger frame of the formal. Even where the formal is explicitly rejected in concrete situations its power to classify lingers on. Opposition and alternative interpretation are endlessly reserved off into exceptions to the rule.

[In a group discussion at school near the end of the last year]

Spanksy It's the lobes [i.e. 'ear'oles'] that make the world we live in, not us.

Fuzz The majority of people are like the lobes, ain't they really. They'll keep it going. If it was left to us (. . .) things'd go really wild and we wouldn't be able to cope.

PW (. . .) would you like things to go that way?

Fuzz No, 'cos you'd just think, you wouldn't be able to own anything, somebody'd be nicking everything.

Spike You're stabbing yourself in the back there.

Fuzz I ain't.

Joey You am, you said if it was left to you, it'd all go wild.

Fuzz It would.

Joey But you wouldn't let it go wild. Then obviously it'd be up to you to stop it.

PW Does that mean you want to be a lobe?

Joey I don' wanna be a lobe, I just wanna be like me.

(. . .)

Joey You're saying you don't want to listen [to the teachers], you've got to listen sometimes. If you walk across there, and there's a big fucking hole in the floor, you'll fall down and break your neck, and you're not listening and you go and do it, then you're killing yourself.

Spanksy [Heatedly] I wouldn't do it, would I?

Joey Why not? You're saying you wouldn't listen (. . .)

PW Since you're saying all this (. . .) and you're intelligent enough to

see it, why aren't you intelligent enough to do it [listen to teachers and conform]?

Joey I ain't saying I'm clever. I'm saying that none of us are clever enough to do it.

PW But you're clever enough to point it out (...) why not do it?

Joey 'Cos nobody else does. I'd be out then I wouldn't be one of these like if I stopped playing up and stopped drinking. I'm an integral part of the group now. I can't get out of it.

Will The teachers are trying to turn us into ear'oles, that's what we come to war'n it, teach us all this stuff, and we don't like ear'oles, so we think, well, if we become like an ear'ole like, we don't like them ourselves, we want to stop as we am.

The oppositional code which upholds the least 'desirable' aspects of 'the lads' culture is most exposed to the dominant ideology. In the face of the internal interlocutor oppositional internal life can become merely an answer. The point here is not that 'the lads' attitude to, say, violence, is right or wrong – for all its brutality it is actually a kind of reflection of competitive individualism under capitalism – but that it is asked to justify itself from within. Though cultural forms and the mediated 'rationality' of concrete actions penetrate it, subvert it or reverse it, the dominant ideology remains to ask questions, the very form of which seals the political out of the cultural.

[In a group discussion]

Spanksy Everybody gets it though, I've got it on me own, he's been bashed on his own, why shouldn't he do it to someone else?

Joey What about wars? You end up shooting some little fat nip. He might have ten kids at home and no wife to support them.

Pete Yeah, it ain't right is it?

Bill You ain't gonna think about that, 'cos while you're standing there thinking about it, he'd kill you.

(...)

Joey If he isn't man enough to take care of himself, or if he isn't er ...

Spanksy Or if I outnumber him four to one ...

Joey Or if he ain't fast enough to run (...)

Derek Well how about Roberts [an 'ear'ole'], when he grows up and he picks on him?

Joey That's his fault, that's his fault for not growing up tough enough.

Derek It ain't his fault, it's probably his mum and dad who ...

Joey It's his own fault ...

Bill Our mum and dad, I bet you, our mum and dad ...

Joey [Heatedly] Well OK, OK then ... It's his mum and dad's fault for bringing him up like a big poof.

Derek 'It's his mum and dad's fault!' You just said it was his fault.

Joey Or if their mum and dad bring them up like a pouf, then it's their fault. It's always somebody's fault, it always goes back to somebody ... 'cos no matter what age I am, I'd like to see some young fucking fifteen year old mug me (...)

PW (...) do you really believe that or is it to try and make it all right somehow?

Joey It's to try and make it alright really.

PW (...) It's important to have the story, why's that?

Joey I dunno, you've always got to justify it. You seem a bit of a cunt if you're just doing it like, er ... I can't explain, really you've got to justify, you've always got to make it seem alright, and there is a reason for doing it (...) This justification is only for me, not for the police. The police, I'd just say, 'I didn't mean to do it' and start crying and all that bollocks, trying to get yourself out of it ... you know, I've got to have some reason for justifying it like. I always feel you'll be called to answer for it, in this life or the next. You'll always be called to answer for the things you do.

PW But if you don't believe it yourself, is it going to help?

Joey It helps to an extent. Some cases, like, you can really justify it and it puts it out of your mind, whereas with others (...) you have to try and think summat out, to try and justify it, on the surface it justifies it, but not deep down. Deep down you know that it ain't right. It's just for when anybody else talks about it, you say, 'Ah well, there's some reason, I wasn't thinking of anything cruel'.

One of the time-honoured principles of cultural and social organisation in this country as it is enacted and understood at the subjective level is that of 'them' and 'us'. [3] That the 'them' survives in 'us' is usually overlooked. This internal division should not be surprising. In a peaceful social democratic society with real class divisions, the 'them' and 'us' can never be starkly clear. This basic distinction must be rehearsed and mediated and echoed around from the largest social units to the individual person. Even the most 'us' group or person has a little of 'them' inside. It is this which allows the 'us' to properly betray itself. Ideology is the 'them' in 'us'. It has been invited. Informality and the strength of personal validation unconnected with a political practice invite it. The very strength of the cultural struggle invites it. Once there it confirms partially and dislocates penetration. It prevents the 'us' from becoming a collective, assertive 'we'. Ideology is allowed to become instead the spurious 'we', the illusory unity from whom all reserve themselves severally but yield a sovereignty in the name of all others. The hall of mirrors of the national will needs each small mirror. Here we have looked at the construction and the interface of just one.

[1] To avoid confusion I do not use the term hegemony but in many ways it would be useful here to denote the precise state of the *relationship* between ideology and located cultural forms. This is the sense in which I take Gramsci's use of the word though I have refrained from using it myself given the uncertainty existing already about its precise meaning. See A. Gramsci, *Prison Notebooks*, Penguin, 1973; P. Anderson, 'Antinomies in Gramsci's Thought', *NLR*, no. 100.

[2] Even amongst some potentially radical workers with a definite political position basic insights about the nature of the capitalist system are often underlaid with a commonsense, absolutist view of the (unpleasant) fixed parameters of human nature which is given no dialectical interconnection at all with determining factors and mediating cultural forms. Social advance can be pictured from this basis as the necessity of a greater authority than capitalism to centrally direct people – even against their will – for the greater good of the whole. This is a skilled 'self-taught' worker in an engineering factory with pronounced, though unaffiliated, left wing leanings:

I'll leave you with a thought. Have you ever been fishing? Well, you know the maggots in the tin? Well, humans in their collectivity, in their tenacity, and in their underlying greed, if you like, filth, nastiness, are just like that. You won't change it. You might get them to run along straight lines [laughs] or put them into compartments, like, but they'll still be maggots like (...). Capitalism's got the glitter, you know, they'll [the people] push through to see the bright lights. They [the capitalists] know that, the bright lights, the holidays in Bermuda, the adverts on the TV. They [the people] all think it will be them, and anyway they like the glitter even though none of them will ever do anything. The capitalists know that, and they know that it will never change. They know people are greedy and all they've got to do is show a little bit of ... glamour. They don't ask the workers to come up, they say it's their fault, 'It wasn't us, they want it ...'. But they still show it. It will never change. *

[3] See for instance the classic work by Richard Hoggart, *The Uses of Literacy*, Chatto & Windus, 1957.

8 Notes towards a theory of cultural forms and social reproduction

Though we have only looked at one of the specific forms of the reproduction of labour power and of the subjective attitudes which allow it to be applied to the production process, there are some broad guides in this study for the development of a more general theory of cultural forms and their role in social reproduction, or more exactly for their role in maintaining the conditions for continued material production in the capitalist mode.

In the first place it warns against a too reductive or crude materialist notion of the cultural level. [1] It is not true, for instance, that the manpower requirements of industry in any direct sense determine the subjective and cultural formation of particular kinds of labour power. [2] Nor is it true that designated institutions such as the school produce – or could produce if in some way better run – classless, standardised packages of labour power. In its desire for workers of a certain type the reach of the production process must pass through the semi-autonomous cultural level which is determined by production only partially and in its own specific terms. Its own terms include consciousness, creativity of collective association, rationality, limitation, unintentionality and division. Its particular contributions to the formation of manual labour, for instance, are a particular kind of affirmation of manual activity and a penetration and transference of sets of divisions (principally manual/mental and male/female). [3]

In a more general sense it cannot be assumed that cultural forms are *determined* in some way as an automatic reflex by macro determinations such as class location, region, and educational background. Certainly these variables are important and cannot be overlooked but *how* do they impinge on behaviour, speech and attitude? We need to understand how structures become sources of meaning and determinants on behaviour in the cultural milieu *at its own level*. Just because there are what we can call structural and economic determinants it does not mean that people will unproblematically obey them. In some societies people are forced at the end of a machine gun to behave in a certain way. In our own this is achieved through apparent freedoms. In order to have a satisfying explanation we need to see what the *symbolic* power of structural determination is within the mediating realm of the human and cultural. It is from the resources of this level that decisions are made which lead to uncoerced outcomes which have the function of maintaining the structure of society and the status quo. Although it is a simplification for our purposes here, and ignoring important forms and forces such as the state, ideology, and various institutions, we can say that macro determinants need to pass through the cultural milieu to reproduce themselves at all.

In the case of job choice amongst the unqualified working class, for instance, we can *predict* final employment quite well from class background, geographical location, local opportunity structure, and educational attainment.[4] Certainly these factors will give us a better guide than expressed intention from individuals say during vocational guidance counselling. But what is it to say in any sense that these variables *determine* job choice? We are still left with the problem of the forms of decision taking and of the apparent basis of willing acceptance of restricted opportunities. To quote the larger factors is really no form of explanation at all. It does not identify a chain or set of causalities which indicate particular outcomes from many possible ones. It simply further outlines the situation which is still in need of explanation: *how* and *why* young people take the restricted and often meaningless available jobs in ways which seem sensible to them in their familiar world as it is actually lived. For a proper treatment of these questions we must go to the cultural milieu which has been studied in this book and we must accept a certain autonomy of the processes at this level which both defeats any simple notion of mechanistic causation and gives the social agents involved some meaningful scope for viewing, inhabiting and constructing their own world in a way which is recognisably human and not theoretically reductive. Settling for manual work is not an experience of absolute incoherence walled from enlightenment by perverse cultural influences, nor is it that of atavistic innocence deeply inscribed upon by pre-given ideologies. It has the profane nature of itself, neither without meaning nor with other's meaning. It can only be lived because it is internally authentic and self made. It is felt, subjectively, as a profound process of learning: it is the organisation of the self in relation to the future.

If a distinctive level of the cultural is to be argued for then, how are we to specify its scope and nature? In my view it is misleading to attempt such a specification in mechanical or structural terms. Culture is not static, or composed of a set of invariant categories which can be read off at the same level in any kind of society. The essence of the cultural and of cultural forms in our capitalist society is their contribution towards the creative, uncertain and tense social reproduction of distinctive kinds of relationships. Cultural reproduction in particular, always carries with it the *possibility* of producing – indeed in a certain sense it really lives out – alternative outcomes. The main relationships which cultural forms help to reproduce are those of its members to the basic class groupings of society and with the productive process. Though the cases vary markedly I do not mean to imply that the main class cultures are conceptually different at this formal level.

Within this larger specification of process it is possible to outline three specific characteristics of the cultural level in our society which help to accomplish this main purpose. In the first place the basic material of the cultural is constituted by varieties of symbolic systems and articulations. These stretch from language to systematic kinds of physical interaction; from particular kinds of attitude, response, action and ritualised behaviour to expressive artefacts and concrete objects. There are likely to be distinctions and contradictions between these forms, so that for instance, actions may belie words, or logics embedded within cultural practices and

rituals may be quite different from particular expressed meanings at the level of immediate consciousness. It is these stresses and tensions which provide the text for the more interpretative analysis required 'beneath' ethnography if the account of a culture is to be in any sense full.

In the second place I suggest that these things are produced at least in part by real forms of cultural production quite comparable with material production. Indeed in such areas as the generation of a distinctive style in clothing or changes made in the physical environment the production *is* material production. The basis for, and impetus of, this production is the informal social group and its collective energies at its own proper level. These energies I suggest are expressed in two connected forms. One is direct. It is the attempt to develop some meaningful account and representation of the world (often in an antagonistic relationship with language) of cultural members' place within it and to experiment with possibilities for gaining some excitement and diversions from it. The other is the profane investigation, the unconsciously revelatory probing of the world and its fundamental organisational categories, made in the course of the first process. The symbolic construction of the cultural world and of possibilities within it (the first) involves work on materials which – especially where they are new, only partially used or not properly ideologically incorporated – can bring real and unexpected results. These importantly derive from the nature of the materials, and the construction of the world, as they are worked upon by human agency for its own purpose. The first process is relatively intentioned – though not on an individual basis. The second can be quite decentred from the particular culture and implies no particular teleology though it importantly influences direct cultural activity and is the basis for its long term relevance and resonance for particular individuals.

Finally I suggest that cultural forms provide the materials towards, and the immediate context of, the construction of subjectivities and the confirmation of identity. It provides as it were the most believable and rewarding accounts for the individual, his future and especially for the expression of his/her vital energies. It seems to 'mark' and 'make sense' of things. I suggest in particular that the individual identity is importantly formed by the culturally learned sense, and subjective inhabitation, of labour power, and, in the reverse moment, that cultural forms themselves are importantly articulated, supported and organised by their members' distinctive sense of labour power and collective mode of effectivity in the world.

These are some of the main forms, functions and distinctive practices to be found at the cultural level. Their basic nature and their own full reproduction can only be understood, however, with respect to the way in which they help to produce the major relationships of the social group to itself to other classes and to the productive process. We might think of this process of reproduction as having two basic 'moments'. In the first place, outside structures and basic class relationships are taken in as symbolic and conceptual relations at the specifically cultural level. The form of this, I suggest, is of cultural (i.e. not centred on the individual or conscious practice) penetrations of the conditions of existence of the social group who support the culture. Structural determinations act, not by direct mechanical

effect, but by mediation through the cultural level where their own relationships become subject to forms of exposure and explanation. In the second 'moment' of the process, structures which have now become sources of meaning, definition and identity provide the framework and basis for decisions and choices in life – in our liberal democracy taken 'freely' – which taken systematically and in the aggregate over large numbers actually helps to reproduce the main structures and functions of society. That is: the factories are filled on Monday morning and on every Monday morning with workers displaying the necessary apparent gradations between mental and manual capacity and corresponding attitudes necessary to maintain, within broad limits, the present structure of class and production. The processes which interact with the penetrations of the first 'moment' to produce a cultural field such that life-decisions are made to reproduce and not refuse or overthrow existing structures I call limitations. Where the penetrations tend towards an exposure of inequality and the determining relationships of capitalism and the construction of a possible basis of collective action for change by the social group concerned, the limitations break up and distort such tendencies and apply them to different ends. The limitations are specific to the cultural level, prevent any essentialist reading of cultural forms, cannot be derived from the production process itself, and include both inherent functional weaknesses of cultural process, the effects of relatively independent meanings systems such as racism and sexism, and the actions of powerful external ideologies. In the case we have studied cultural penetrations of the special nature of labour in modern capitalism become a strangled muted celebration of masculinity in labour power. Cultural penetrations stop short of any concrete resistance or construction of political alternatives in an unillusioned acceptance of available work roles and a mystified use of them for a certain cultural advantage and resonance – especially concerning sexism and male expressivity. We should not underestimate the surviving degree of rationality and insight here. That working situation is given only the minimum of intrinsic interest and involvement. The self-abnegation of living subordination as equality, and in the terms of the official ideology, in the face of daily evidence and experience to the contrary, is at least denied.

The argument here, then, is that cultural forms cannot be reduced or regarded as the mere epiphenomenal expression of basic structural factors. They are not the accidental or open-ended determined variables in the couplet structure/culture. They are part of a necessary circle in which neither term is thinkable alone. It is in the passage through the cultural level that aspects of the real structural relationships of society are transformed into conceptual relationships and back again. The cultural is part of the necessary dialectic of reproduction. [5]

This view of cultural forms and reproduction is both pessimistic and optimistic. It is pessimistic in suggesting the irony that it is in the form of creative penetrations that cultures live their own damnation and that, for instance, a good section of working class kids condemn themselves to a future in manual work. It is optimistic, however, in showing that there is no inevitability of outcomes. Subordination and failure is not unanswerable. If there are moments when cultural forms make real

penetrations of the world then no matter what distortions follow, there is always the possibility of strengthening and working from this base. If there has been a radical genesis of conservative outcomes then at least there exists a *capacity* for opposition. We have the logical possibility of radicalness. Structuralist theories of reproduction [6] present the dominant ideology (under which culture is subsumed) as impenetrable. Everything fits too neatly. Ideology always pre-exists and pre-empts any authentic criticism. There are no cracks in the billiard ball smoothness of process. All specific contradictions and conflicts are smoothed away in the universal reproductive functions of ideology. This study suggests on the contrary, and in my view more optimistically, that there are deep disjunctions and desperate tensions within social and cultural reproduction. Social agents are not passive bearers of ideology, but active appropriators who reproduce existing structures only through struggle, contestation and a partial penetration of those structures. [7] Quite apart from a particular society's structural characteristics, it is the type of this contested settlement which helps to give it its special nature. A society, for instance, is deeply marked by the specific forms in which its labour power is prepared.

This warning against too closed or pre-emptive a notion of cultural forms and reproduction is also a case for recognising a necessary uncertainty. Too often it is assumed that capitalism implies thoroughly effective domination of the subordinate class. Far from this, capitalism in its modern, liberal democratic forms *is* permanent struggle. What is accommodating in working class culture is also what is resistant so that capitalism is never secure. It can never be a dynasty. Insofar as it has a stability it is the dynamic one of risking instability by yielding relative freedoms to circles of unintention in the hope of receiving back a minimum consent for rule. There is thus a deep uncertainty and changing balance of ever-heightening contradictions at the heart of capitalism. Full contested cultural reproduction is more important to capitalism than to any other system but the conditions for its own survival are also the conditions for its replacement.

Capitalist freedoms are potentially real freedoms and capitalism takes the wager, which is the essence of reproduction, that the freedoms will be used for self-damnation. The dominant class could never batten down the hatch on these freedoms without help from below. And if these freedoms are not used at this time for their full subversive, oppositional or independent purposes capitalism will not take the blame. It makes its own wager on uncertainty, others can make theirs.

The profound – though not limitless – uncertainty at the heart of the system should also warn against too functionalist a view of class cultural processes. Certainly, for instance, the circles of contradiction and unintention described in this book 'work' for capitalism at this point in time. But so must any system 'work' which is stable enough to be studied. There must therefore always be a functional level of analysis in reproduction. But this must not be allowed to obscure the struggles which through uncertainties motor the working parts. Many aspects of 'the lads' culture, for instance, are challenging and subversive and remain threatening. There are many breaks, lags, antagonisms, deep struggles and real subversive

logics within and behind cultural processes of reproduction which fight for outcomes other than those which satisfy the system for the moment.

This uncertainty also warns against any simple teleological notion of capitalist development. The huge growth of the state in welfare and education, for instance, is not necessarily in any 'best' interests of capitalism. It has to some extent been forced on it by competing groups using their own real freedoms for self-advancement as they have seen it. Of course state agencies have been utilised and modified to help cool out, or drive out, problems which capitalism produces but cannot solve. But whilst they help to solve problems these institutions cannot wholly be absorbed back into capitalism. They maintain spaces and potential oppositions, keep alive issues, and prod nerves which capitalism would much rather were forgotten. Their personnel are in no simple sense servants of capitalism. They solve, confuse or postpone its problems in the short term very often because of their commitment to professional goals which are finally and awkwardly independent from the functional needs of capitalism. They may help, unconsciously, in unintended forms of class reproduction but all the same this may also involve the heightening of opposition and criticism which the dominant class could well do without. State agencies and institutions often take contradictions further, and faster, and in stranger, more displaced and disoriented forms, than any pure capitalism could dream of. The bureaucratic educational welfare state machine so characteristic of Western capitalism must be seen in part as the result of a cumulative encrustment which capitalism manages to turn to its advantage rather than as the expression of its own will or straightforward domination. Its own uncertainty makes it prone to mutation and further gives it life in mutation.

Reproduction and state institutions

This study gives more precise suggestions, especially concerning the significance of systematic misrecognition and unintended consequence, for conceptualising the role of institutions in cultural and social reproduction.

In the first place we must not expect particular kinds of reproduction to take place tidily in discrete kinds of institution. Just as the school and its formal timetable lies tangential to the real processes of learning and of the preparation of manual labour power, other kinds of institution may lie awkwardly against real social functions. The particular meaning and scope of the role of institutions in reproduction may be less to do with their formal nature and manifest communications than with the unintended and often unseen results of their relationships and habituated patterns of interaction with located and informal cultures. Furthermore, the same institution may play very different roles in different kinds of reproduction, so that, for instance, the school is more central to the preparation of mental labour power than to manual labour power.

In the second place it suggests that institutions cannot be studied as simple unities. They have at least three levels which we might describe as the official, the

pragmatic and the cultural. At the official level an institution is likely to have a formal account of its purpose in relation to its view of the main structural and organisational features of society and how they interrelate (or might be made to interrelate). In a liberal democratic society such as ours, it would be quite wrong to assume that state institutions like the school are run in any obvious or intentional way for the benefit of the dominant class (as are private schools for instance). Their conscious and centrally directed aim is not to promote two very different kinds of ideology suited to the needs of acknowledged inferior and superior classes. Their educated, concerned and honest liberal agents would not countenance that. Furthermore, this level of institutional practice is most directly related to the political realm proper and all the determinants and interests which operate there. Part of the dominant social democratic political pressure since the war has been to equalise provision, or at least to equalise access to provision through the reform and development of institutions. Convergence, not divergence, has been the main official tendency.

It is, of course, an absolute requirement for the existing social system that the same standards, ideologies and aspirations are not really passed on to all. The success of the official ideology, or what amounts to the same thing the demise of its oppositional cultural reproduction, in many institutions would be catastrophic for social reproduction in general. The 'transition' from school to work, for instance, of working class kids who had really absorbed the rubric of self-development, satisfaction and interest in work, would be a terrifying battle. Armies of kids equipped with their 'self-concepts' would be fighting to enter the few meaningful jobs available, and masses of employers would be struggling to press them into meaningless work. In these circumstances there would indeed be a much greater 'problem' of 'careers guidance' than we have now. Either a gigantic propaganda exercise of wartime proportions or direct physical coercion would be needed to get the kids into the factories. Since this is not yet required, and since social reproduction of the class society in general continues despite the intervention of the liberal state and its institutions, it may be suggested that some of the real functions of institutions work counter to their stated aims. This misrecognition, it can be suggested, helps to maintain many of the cultural processes taking place within particular institutions which contribute towards social reproduction. At the second, the pragmatic level, official ideologies and aims are mediated to the agents and functionaries of particular institutions. They are likely to appreciate something of the more theoretical rationale for the prevailing or coming 'official' ideology, but they are also mainly interested in their own face to face problems of control and direction and the day to day pressures of their own survival within the inherited institution. They run a practical eye over 'official' ideology. They will adopt newly sanctioned ideologies, for instance, only when they seem to offer real and practical help - though they may well justify the change, even to themselves, with the rubric of the purer received ideology. It is this practical engagement which very often prevents the agents from seeing what is happening below them.

At the third level 'below' the others are the cultural forms of adaption of the

institution's clients as their outside class experience interacts with the practical exigencies and processes of the institution as they strike them. One of the important variants of this is likely to be an oppositional informal culture which may well actually help to accomplish the wider social reproduction which the official policy has been trying to defeat or change. As we have seen in this book, where they occur at a cultural level the destruction of official myths and illusions and a canny assessment of the world do not stop incorporation into that world. They can aid it. If the specificity of the institution and vulnerability of its ideology help to promote certain kinds of oppositional cultures and their characteristic penetrations it also helps to disorientate them into their accommodative mode by providing or strengthening powerful limitations. In particular it is likely to generate divisions especially in the area of its own proper concerns and also between the formal and informal. Though the school, for instance, is not effective in the way it hopes to be, it is an extremely important location, and proximate cause of renaissance of oppositional class culture experienced by a good percentage of working class boys during their 3rd, 4th and 5th years at school. This renaissance leads to changes and refinements in the subjective inhabitation of labour power which lead to very concrete outcomes. In contradictory and unintended ways the counter-school culture actually achieves for education one of its main though misrecognised objectives – the direction of a proportion of working kids 'voluntarily' to skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled manual work. Indeed far from helping to cause the present 'crisis' in education, the counter-school culture and the processes it sponsors has helped to prevent a real crisis.

I suggest that all major changes in institutional organisation might be thought through in terms of these three levels. In the case of education, for instance, progressivism has been developed and theorised as an official ideology by academics in conjunction with wider social democratic, political and institutional movements to increase educational provision and access for the working class. At the pragmatic level, however, progressivism is taken up in schools mainly as a practical solution to practical problems without any real shift in basic philosophies of education. At the cultural level it can be argued that often 'progressivism' has had the contradictory and unintended effect of helping to strengthen processes within the counter-school culture which are responsible for the particular subjective preparation of labour power and acceptance of a working class future in a way which is the very opposite of progressive intentions in education. It is this strengthened cultural reproduction in relation to the school which of course guarantees the future of educational experiment by always limiting the scope of its success.

This is no simple argument against, or criticism of, progressivism or other kinds of institutional reform. Any kind of educational, or other, change will encounter its own forms of unintention, contradiction, and unseen forms of reproduction in complex links to class cultures and the objective requirements of the outside system. This is rather the point: that no institutional objectives, no moral or pedagogic initiative, moves in the clear still air of good intention and Newtonian cultural mechanics. Every move must be considered in relation to its context and likely

circles of effectiveness within the netherworld (usually to institutional and official eyes) of cultural reproduction and the main world of social class relationships.

Progressivism and RSLA, for instance, have actually addressed real problems, have protected kids a little longer from the harshness and inequality of industry, and have helped to give them – in unintended and unexpected ways of course – a definite kind of insight and cultural advance not available to their parents. We must not, simply, be naive about what is meant by advance. We must ask in what form, for whom, in which direction, and through what circles of unintention, with what reproductive consequences for the social system in general, particular advances are made.

Of course there is a danger in generalisation and extrapolation. Different agencies and institutions have different dominant/subordinate, professional/client relations, different lags, breaks and reversals of ideology, different moments and points of struggle, different intersections with the class system and modes of cultural reproduction. It is possible to suggest, however, that, if nothing else, many institutions may share, in some way and at some level, a self-deluding belief in the unity of their own official ideology. What is certain is that such ideology is not uncritically transmitted downwards until those at the bottom in some way receive and have and are nothing. At some point there is a break and reversal in this ideological chain which has extremely important connections with, and crucial reproductive functions with respect to, the rest of the social system. It might be suggested that in many institutions it is the characteristic sense of cultural penetration (impeded by limitations) which actually motivates members in concrete actions, and that it is often in the Parthian victory of informal mastery and control that social reproduction is decisively sealed.

Notes

[1] Marx, for instance, never explains how labour power comes to be formed, subjectively inhabited, given an applied to the production process in a certain way. There is almost a sleight of hand in the conceptual use of the reserve army of the unemployed to explain the ideological obedience of workers. No matter what the immediate pressures and the added force of competition, we still need to understand the processes which produce large supplies of labour power of a certain kind in the first place – unemployed or not.

[2] Though I have argued that production does not mechanically determine the cultural level and those processes there which help to form the labour power it requires, it is nevertheless clear that the workers who are produced in whatever way must broadly satisfy the global needs of production at any particular point. These requirements are to some extent influenced by the forms in which they are satisfied and vice-versa but we still need to confront the manner of articulation of their relatively independent logics and development. A few preliminary comments can be made in this complex area from the evidence of this study.

The emergence of monopoly capitalism marks an unprecedented move towards control and intensification of the labour process. Competitive capitalism with the greater centrality of the market place in commodity exchange had acted as a brake on this control. It supplied the possibility of concrete alternatives for the individual labourer if a particular job became too arduous. It also tended to set a limit on the pace of technological advance and innovation because investment in these things risked too long a cycle of capital return (or even an insufficient return if the investment were made not for optimal build up of capital but for competitive product advance) to be viable in the short run interests which prevail on the free market. (This is the same logic which prevents individual capitalists from introducing the shorter working day: see Marx, *Capital*, Aveling and Moor (translations, p. 256). The modern corporation is relatively insulated from these market pressures and can proceed with the control and intensification of the labour power it buys the use of more according to its own internal logic of production. There is a real tendency towards increased intensification of labour processes, and a further wresting of control from, and decomposition of craft skills (c.f. Braverman, *Labour and Monopoly Capital*, Monthly Review Press). Control has moved centrally and upwards for the specialised and rationalised control of large scale production. There is, therefore, a need in general (that is, apart from the still small highly skilled fraction which has control passed on to it) for a less skilled workforce open to greater systematisation and a higher working pace coupled with a degree of flexibility to allow interchange between increasingly standardised processes. In a word, monopoly capitalism requires an accelerated shift in its workforce from craft 'idiocy', pride in the job, and personal fusion in work activity.

The cultural and institutional processes described in this book – taken as a whole – tend to produce large numbers of workers approaching this type. The nature of the 'partial penetrations' we have looked at are precisely to devalue and discredit older attitudes to work, feelings of control and meaning at work. In certain respects these developments are progressive with respect to monopoly capital and are likely to supply the instrumental, flexible, un-illusioned, 'sharp', unskilled but well-socialised workers needed to take part in its increasingly socialised work processes.

The 'advancedness' of proletarian workers must not, of course, go too far. The desertion of old skills, mystiques, and protective attitudes must not become the rejection of modern work or a complete understanding of its meaninglessness. The freedom, independence and willingness to change of the new instrumental workers must not be allowed to degenerate into lack of loyalty and erosion of motivations of any kind. Most of all, the objectives social interdependence of these advanced proletarian workers – with fewer prejudices, blindnesses and limitations than any before – must not become an interdependence and solidarity of *consciousness* and political purpose.

The demands arising from modern monopolies are therefore mutually contradictory. Their need for a more advanced (or less skilled and job bound) kind of worker also invites a worker without loyalty and motivation, one who is potentially susceptible to mass critical political perspectives.

This contradiction is, however, I suggest also likely to be partly saved by the cultural forms in which labour power is supplied. If industry's needs for a more flexible and unillusioned worker are mainly satisfied by one kind of working class cultural processes (in a mediated relation to these very needs of course), this culture also provides (again in a mediated relation) other processes which produce forms of attachment, divisions and unexpected motivation which go some way towards meeting its needs for a kind of loyalty and political dislocation. The conformist cultural variants of the preparation of labour power, especially in relation to the non-conformist ones, are likely to produce workers who are committed to their activity and likely to believe in the intrinsic value of work and associated qualifications even despite their tenuous objective substance. Furthermore the mere existence of these opposed forms of attachment creates the basis for hierarchy and division in the workforce which can be exploited to break up solidarity and also legitimate, ideologically, real class divisions. These sets of cultural bifurcations and distortions which derive from the semi-autonomous cultural level make it, in fact, extremely difficult to 'see through' them to judge, empirically, actual changes in the production process. Still, it may be suggested that for the moment the needs of industry and the cultural forms of the reproduction of labour power seem to be moving in a rough if contradictory harmony. The long run contradiction cannot, however, be resolved. The ideological and material processes move in fundamentally opposite directions. The labour process itself is becoming more de-skilled and proletarianised, whilst jobs within it are apparently becoming more stratified and differentiated – especially as regards qualifications. It must remain an open question whether the elemental divisions between manual and mental labour and between sex genders in the working class will continuously reproduce and extend divisions when the objective technical divisions of the productive process are further lessening.

One of the most interesting management innovations in the control and direction of a changing workforce is the 'new' human relations: techniques of work re-structuring, job satisfaction and autonomous work groupings.* There has been a good deal of bafflement concerning the inner logic of these techniques in relation to forms of worker consciousness and resistance. In my view the most illuminating perspective on these developments is to see it as a response to an advance (in contradiction) of proletarian consciousness. Strict division of the labour process and high morale and company loyalty are becoming harder to enforce as working class cultural forms and associated actions may be seen to press through its self-imposed mental/manual barriers towards a lived understanding of abstract labour, through its own sexist barriers to the strict meaninglessness of work, to a greater informal control of work, and to a greater oppositional solidarity – at least in the powerful realm of the located and informal. The 'new' human relations marks a preemptive attempt by management to contain this developing consciousness, and utilise it for a greater flexibility and higher motivation.

The final price for such a strategic settlement might be quite high, both in the sense that the strict productive logic of the greatest efficiency (a prime tenet for

capitalist stability) has been abandoned, and also that conditions are created more conducive to the development of more critical and challenging views amongst the workforce. In the short term it is possible that production might rise because of less disruption, and opposition decrease because of the relative atomisation of the workforce. If we characterise the whole move, however, as the ordered internalisation – on conditions – of the foreman into the informal culture which otherwise anarchically usurps and challenges his role, then we can see that there is a strict limit to dealing with opposition to, say, the managing director in this way. Concessions and devaluation of authority from the formal to the informal is a dangerous strategy, and all forms of participation are two-edged. The wager for capitalism must be whether it can come to a new stabilised division between control and obedience, or whether it is set in action on a permanent gentle slope of minor concessions. We may expect an ideological build up of division and legitimisation, so to speak, further up the river, to choke off too much ambition in claims for control of the workplace.

Another way to conceptualise these changes in management technique is to picture the focus of conscious management enterprise moving from the forces of production to the relations of production. Where previously these relations had been seen simply as supplying the conditions for the operation of the forces of production, they are now being conceived of as forces in their own right.

Taylorism and Fordism are aimed at increasing the efficient and rational utilisation of the forces of production. This involves an objective socialisation of production which is likely, in its turn, to bring about what we might think of as a socialisation of consciousness where interdependence is massively recognised and used by workers to control production. Taylor was partly working in his own time against 'gold bricking' and 'systematic soldiering', but the very rationalisation and expansion of production produced by his techniques in this way creates the conditions for a greater informal control of the work process. Manipulation and control of the forces of production therefore bring real visible consequences for the social relations of production which themselves act back on the forces.

We can understand the first wave of human relations, originating in the work of Elton Mayo, as an attempt to stulify and freeze the counterproductive tendencies of the social relations of production thus affected. These 'Mark I' HR techniques in no sense consciously reorganise the forces of production to take account of social relations. They operate within the group itself – at the superstructural level so to speak – to manage, manipulate and accommodate group processes, particularly through the influence of the group leader.

The emergence of the second wave of human relations techniques marks the limits of these 'idealist' solutions. There is a more materialist conception of the informal group and workplace cultures at play. Instead of merely trying to limit the unfortunate consequences of informal group activity within a fixed labour process, the labour process itself is recognised as a determinant of the informal group, and its manipulation is entertained as a means of controlling cultural forms. The success or failure of this so far limited micro-experiment of a controlled test-tube socialism

might be less important than capitalism's recognition, at certain pressure points, that it is the social relations of production which materially limit production and not the inadequate development of the forces of production. We see here the infinite variety of resources and flexibility in capitalism as it sets its acid to work on the conditions of its own supremacy. It may even be right to think yet again that the entanglements of working class radicalism will be worse confounded by free concession, and that a new level of stasis is possible within a further mutated capitalist system.

*See for instance, Mary Weir (ed.) *Job Satisfaction*, Fontana, 1976; P. Warr and T. Wall, *Work and Well-Being*, Penguin, 1975; N. A. B. Wilson, *On the Quality of Working Life: A Report Prepared for the Department of Employment*, Manpower Papers, No. 7, HMSO, 1973; Report of a Special Task Force to the Secretary of Health, Education and Welfare, *Work in America*, MIT Press, 1973; W. I. Paul and K. B. Robertson, *Job Enrichment and Employee Motivation*, Gower Press, 1970; F. Herzberg, *Work and the Nature of Man*, Staple Press, 1968.

[3] Elements of the productive process do have to bear the weight of, reproduce in some form and return, such ideological constructions placed on its own processes.

[4] A point made tellingly by Ken Roberts in criticism of the careers service and the centrality of vocational guidance in the school within it, 'Where is the careers service heading', *Careers Bulletin*, DE, 1976.

[5] In this attempt to criticise a reductive or epiphenomenal reading I do not wish to imply that structures are either fully transformed into ideas and symbols – this would be to posit an historicist clarity of cultural forms which I have rejected – or do not have alternative modes of effectively on the cultural and other levels through ideology, the state and institutions. There are other forms of social reproduction than the cultural which is why I have separated the terms.

[6] See for instance, L. Althusser, 'Ideology and Ideological State Apparatuses' in B. R. Cosin (ed.), *Education: Structure and Society*, Penguin, 1972.

[7] Mainstream sociology too, with its notion of socialisation, and its implication of passive transmission, misses the tension and uncertainty of this process. It is not that the working class is for all time different from the middle class (for whatever reason) and passes on its disadvantages timelessly and unbreakably to succeeding generations (cf. the cycle of poverty and like theories) through ineluctable laws of socialisation.

Cultural patterns and activities and attitudes are developed in precise conjunction with real exigencies, and are produced and reproduced in each generation for its own good reasons. Patterns of the development of labour power for a specific kind of application to industry must in every generation be achieved, developed and worked for in struggle and contestation. If certain obvious features of this continuous reproduction and ever freshly struck settlement show a degree of visible continuity over time this should not lead us to construct iron laws and dynamics of socialisation from this mere succession of like things. The

underworkings of these continuities are more complex, uncertain, related outwards, and liable to change than can be contained in the notion of socialisation.

9 Monday morning and the millennium

For a mass of people to be led to think coherently (. . .) about the real, present world, is a 'philosophical' event far more important and 'original' than the discovery by some philosophical 'genius' of a truth which remains the property of small groups of intellectuals (. . .) it is not a question of introducing from scratch a scientific form of thought into everyone's individual life, but of renovating and making 'critical' an already existing activity.

Antonio Gramsci,
from the *Prison Notebooks*,
pp. 325 and 330

The introduction posed the question of how and why it is that working class lads come to accept working class jobs through their own apparent choice. We can say that for a good proportion, the disaffected - in relation to whom the conformist case can be better understood - this is in the form of a partial cultural penetration of their own real conditions and a mystified celebration of manual work which nevertheless preserves something of a collective, rational, though incomplete, logic. I have suggested that this can be understood as a form of cultural reproduction which helps to contribute towards social reproduction in general. Some of the theoretical implications of this position are tentatively explored in the previous chapter. Finally I would like to consider some of the implications of this research for the practical/political level and particularly for the two regions most clearly involved with the concerns of this study: vocational guidance and education for disaffected working class youth.

The whole level of cultural presentation, analysis and determination explored in this book suggests the general possibility of effectivity at the cultural level. This seems especially so if, as I argue, cultural processes of reproduction pass through a moment of real penetration and potential radical solidarity. With the frequency with which cultural forms reproduce the old they have challenged the old. A naive reading of this position might suggest that a simple intervention might be made, or a direct separation made in some way between the progressive and the regressive. The problem with this interpretation is, of course, that it forgets the essential unity of the cultural level (which the ethnographic account for instance insists upon) and overlooks the complex ways in which the cultural has specifically internal weaknesses which are part of its nature and which are easily invaded by ideology.

Furthermore the cultural level is in no sense free-floating. It has a mediated relationship to structural factors and often a precise material and organisational institutional context which underwrite characteristic forms of relationship, patterns of balance and complementarity. The couplet accommodation/resistance is riveted tight. The terms do not often shake themselves loose and will not by mere wishing.